EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The *Digital News Report: Australia 2026* shows how news consumption and trust are shaped by external factors, particularly during periods of crisis and political events. The past year was marked by global crises, the Bondi Beach shooting, and the federal election. Many Australians turned to trusted news sources to understand and make sense of these complex developments.

After several years of decline, interest in news has increased, placing Australia well above the global average. This recovery has been driven largely by audiences that typically have low news interest, including women and young people. Interest in politics has also risen among U35s, who now have higher levels of political interest than older cohorts for the first time.

These short term shifts sit within a much larger pattern of long term change. This year's analysis of Australians' evolving news habits highlights a widening generational divide, driven by increasing fragmentation in how, when, and where people access news. For younger audiences, news consumption is unfixed and fluid, largely shaped by their heavy reliance on social media. However, they continue to express high levels of concern about online misinformation and are active news avoiders, reflecting their low trust in the news they see on social media.

This year's findings underscore the growing influence of creators and influencers within the global news environment. Their role is increasingly significant in shaping how audiences discover, interpret, and engage with information.

Audiences who turn to these figures for news tend to value perspectives that either reflect or thoughtfully challenge their own views, rather than maintaining a neutral or undefined stance. This preference does not necessarily indicate a desire for partisanship; rather, it reflects a demand for authenticity. Audiences are seeking news that breaks down complex stories, offers a clear viewpoint, and demonstrates a sense of purpose.

Equally important is the style of delivery. Audiences, particularly younger demographics, are drawn to news that feels personal, relatable, and conversational. Instead of polished and formal formats, they favour storytelling that resembles the way a trusted friend might share and explain events.

Younger audiences in particular are increasingly relying on influencers as a primary source of news and information. This shift appears to be more than a temporary change in platform preference. It isn't just about consumers moving to different platforms; they are choosing more direct forms of journalism.

In an increasingly crowded digital environment, where audiences are exposed to an abundance of news and information, people gravitate toward trusted sources. When audiences judge news coverage to be of poor quality, levels of distrust are markedly higher. Conversely, trust improves when news organisations are seen to deliver accurate, reliable, and well-produced reporting. Higher perceived quality strengthens trust, and greater trust, in turn, is associated with more active news consumption. This basic principle is critical to the sustainability and relevance of news organisations in an increasingly complex and uncertain media landscape.

Australians are consuming more news

News consumption in Australia increased by 3 percentage points in 2026, with the proportion of Australians accessing news more than once a day reaching 56%. This is largely driven by the increased news use among U35s and women, who are typically lighter news consumers. This is partly related to the growth of social media as a source of news. Seventy-one percent (+9) of 18–24-year-olds, and 57% (+7) of women access news on social media on a weekly basis.

Social media is now the second most used news source (56%, +9) in Australia behind TV (57%). It has also become the main pathway (32%) to online news, overtaking direct access to news websites (31%) for the first time. This means that control over the visibility of news to audiences is increasingly mediated by digital platforms, and publishers are relying on the click-through rates.

While TV remains the most widely used main source of news, its dominance is eroding over time. People are migrating online to watch news videos (73%, +6), and 29% are using video apps, such as YouTube, on their smart TVs. This is more than half (57%) of smart TV news users.

Video platforms are driving increased engagement with news on social media

Social media continues to play a growing and complex role in how Australians access and interact with news. In 2026, video first platforms and instant messaging apps are driving the biggest growth.

Facebook remains the most widely used social media platform for news, despite Meta's algorithmic strategy to deprioritise news. Older respondents have increased their consumption of news on Facebook, while younger audiences increasingly prefer video-based platforms such as TikTok and Instagram. Nearly half of Australians aged 18–24 use TikTok for news, making it the top platform among this group.

Facebook (39%) and YouTube (34%) now outperform news websites and apps (26%) to watch news videos. Short form video dominates across platforms, with most watching news videos under two minutes (Facebook, 71%; Instagram, 71%). However, YouTube stands out as the main platform for longer news videos (40%), especially among highly educated and politically engaged audiences. This preference for news videos reflects the widespread use of smart TVs for news (52%).

Changing news habits

Large proportions of Australians report having stopped using traditional news media over their lifetimes, most notably newspapers and radio. Two in five (40%) Australians say they previously read newspapers regularly but no longer do so, far exceeding the proportion who have stopped using television (26%) or online news (15%). There is a big generational divide; many 18–24-year-olds have never used newspapers (60%), radio (53%) or TV (25%) as a news source. Fewer people report having stopped using online news (15%), suggesting its potential to grow.

Australians are more loyal towards news brands than consumers in other countries. We are among the most loyal in the world in using the same brands every day. Around one third (34%) of Australians say they use the same news brands daily and brand loyalty is higher among older audiences, regional consumers, and those with low education. However, younger people are less attached to specific brands and more likely to use a wide range of sources. About half of U35s (18–24, 43%; 25–34, 50%) access more than seven news brands on a weekly basis. This includes news brands people access offline, online and on social media.

Overall, younger Australians are more flexible with their news consumption habits, and older generations are more fixed in their routines. While most Australians consistently use the same devices to access news, fewer maintain regular patterns in when, where, and how often they do it or what they're looking at. Social media users are especially likely to access news irregularly, with high exposure to incidental news. Younger audiences are the least consistent across time, place, devices and brands, suggesting a shift away from habitual news routines.

Creators and influencers are becoming a significant part of Australia's news ecosystem

Creators and influencers are becoming an important part of Australia's news landscape. Four in ten Australian news consumers (43%) access news from individual creators or influencers, a rate similar to the global average (46%). This signals a shift in how audiences discover and engage with news, especially among U35s, almost three-quarters get news from influencers (18–24, 70%; 25–34, 72%).

News from creators and influencers appears to complement rather than replace mainstream news. More than half of users say these creators meet only some of their news needs, with most still relying on other sources of news. However, many young people rely on influencers for news. More than half of U35s (18–24s, 52%; 25–34s, 53%) say that creators and influencers meet all or most of their news needs. Those who do prefer news from influencers say it is more entertaining (59%), relatable (55%), and easy to understand (56%) than mainstream news.

Trust in news encountered on social media is related to use of influencers for news. Audiences who distrust mainstream

news and curate news content on social platforms are more likely to seek news from influencers for their perceived authenticity and relatability.

The influencer news market is highly fragmented. Consumers name hundreds of different individuals, journalists, and personalities, with low concentration even among top influencers. While this fragmentation may offer a diverse range of perspectives to audiences, it also produces a wide variation in quality and a lack of consistent industry standards, which may further erode trust in the wider news environment. Influencers are unlikely to replace mainstream news in the near future, but audiences are signalling a clear desire for news that feels more accessible, engaging and relevant.

Interaction with news is growing

Australians are increasingly likely to talk about news (40%, +6), read comments on social media (39%, +8), and engage with news content on social media (20%, +4) or via an instant messenger (19%, +6). These interaction behaviours have grown steadily since 2024, particularly among younger people. However, clear gender gaps persist. Men are more visible contributors through commenting and sharing, while women prefer to just read others' comments.

Generative AI for news

Generative AI chatbots are emerging as an important part of the Australian news ecosystem. In 2026, nearly one in ten Australians (9%) report using tools such as ChatGPT, Gemini, or Perplexity to get their news, which is broadly in line with the global average (9%). Usage is unevenly distributed, with significantly higher adoption among men, younger people, those with higher education and income, and people who live in the city. The use of AI to access news is much higher among people who already pay for online news and have strong interest in news and politics. Trust also plays a central role in AI news use. People who trust news generally, especially from AI chatbots, are much more likely to use these tools. Among people who use AI chatbots for news, they most often used them to ask follow-up questions (49%), summarise (45%), and get the latest news (44%). AI users also turned to chatbots to make news easier to understand and to help explain complex issues. The top reasons for using AI chatbots for news is to collate stories from different news sources (50%) and to ask follow-up questions to get more in-depth explanation (43%).

The intermediary role of digital platforms

We asked users how often they click through to original content on digital platforms. People report higher click-through rates to news sources when using search engines (45%), and lower click-throughs when using AI chatbots (38%), or social and video networks (37%). AI use is still in its early stages with highly engaged users, and this pattern may change over time if it becomes more mainstream. Motivations for clicking through to original news sources also differ by platform. Across search engines and social media, the primary reason to click is to obtain more detailed information. On AI platforms, people want to verify the accuracy of the information.

Public service media are gaining the support of younger audiences

Around half (49%) of Australians believe public service media (PSM) have a positive effect on life in Australia, well above the global average of 36%. Younger adults, particularly those aged 25–34 (68%) are far more positive about PSM than those aged 55–64 (34%) and 65+ (38%). To Australians, ensuring everyone has access to important national and local news is the most positive aspect of PSM. While older Australians' use of PSM has declined since 2022, engagement among younger audiences has grown significantly from 43% in 2022 to 54% in 2026 among 18–24s.

Australians are evenly split on whether the news media are doing a good or bad job

Respondents are more likely to think that news organisations are doing a good job reporting on inflation and cost of living (36%) than other topics. On immigration only 23% say the news media are doing a good job. Perceptions of news quality vary sharply across demographics. Younger audiences, men, those with higher education, and heavy news consumers are consistently more positive. In contrast, regional Australians are less satisfied than those in major cities, highlighting perceived gaps in local relevance and representation. Payment status is also strongly linked to perceptions of quality. People who pay for online news are more likely to rate coverage as high quality across all topics.

Most Australians prefer news without a strong point of view

Almost half (49%) of Australians prefer news from sources that do not take a particular point of view. Only one in five (17%) favour news that aligns with their own viewpoint, and the same number seek news from sources that challenge their views. Those aged 25–34 (30%), are more likely to value news that reflects their own viewpoints.

Paying for news is stable

The proportion of Australians paying for online news remains steady (23%). Australia continues to be one of the strongest global markets for paid digital news, beaten only by a small number of Nordic countries. Globally, however, willingness to pay for online news appears to have plateaued amid the persistent cost of living crisis.

Among those who do pay, Australia stands out with 35% of people paying for digital-only news organisations, which is well above the global average of 23%. This payment pattern is driven by U35s, who are the most active in paying for digital-only news subscriptions (47%).

Ongoing digital subscriptions (14%) continue to grow and have doubled since 2019 (7%). This suggests that while fewer new people are entering the paid news market, those who do pay are settling into regular news subscription habits.

Younger and more highly educated audiences are driving the growth in news payment. Payment has risen most sharply among those under 35s with higher education, widening the gap between younger and older Australians.

There are key reasons Australians pay for news: to access unique content (46%) and avoid advertising (39%), followed closely by paying for news they use to pass the time (38%). Many also cite supporting journalism as a social good or having aligned values with a particular news organisation as important reasons. These social good motivations are especially pronounced among younger audiences, with 30% of U35s paying to ensure news remains freely available to others compared to only 15% among those aged 35+.

Australians who use news influencers or creators as a source of news are also substantially more likely to pay for news overall (38%). These users tend to be more active and fluid in their news habits, spreading their payments across a wider range of outlets, including digital only publications, aggregators, and individual journalists.

Trust remains low, along with persistently high concern about misinformation

Australians' trust in news is unchanged in 2026 (43%), while trust in my news has risen to 54% (+5), widening the gap in trust between news people choose to consume and the broader news environment. In contrast, trust in news on social media (21%) and from AI chatbots (19%) is very low.

Strikingly, there was an increase in news trust among U35s since 2024, who now have higher trust in both news generally (U35, 50% vs. 35+, 40%) and *my news* (U35, 60% vs. 35+, 51%) than older Australians — reversing a long-standing age gap.

Trust is highest in public service media news brands, with perceived quality of journalism one of the strongest predictors of trust. Australians who believe news organisations are doing a good job reporting on major issues — such as climate change or cost of living — are much more likely to say they trust the news. Belief in the positive social role of PSM is also strongly associated with higher trust.

People who distrust news are much more likely to avoid it and to express strong concern about misinformation. Overall, concern about what is real or fake online continues to grow (77%, +3) — the highest level of concern globally — which reflects the rising use of social platforms and AI chatbots for news.

News avoidance remains widespread

Despite rising interest in news, more than two thirds (68%) of Australians continue to avoid it. Avoidance is especially high among women (71%), 18–24-year-olds (83%), and those who distrust news (80%). Avoidance has increased sharply among the youngest cohort, even though their news consumption and interest have grown, indicating a pattern of intermittent engagement. High concern about misinformation and distrust in news, particularly on social media, are strongly associated with higher levels of avoidance.

News organisations face the challenge of engaging audiences who are simultaneously curious and cautious, highly connected but resistant to fixed routines or brand loyalty. Predicting future news behaviours — especially among younger cohorts — will become increasingly difficult as habits continue to adapt to new platforms, formats and emerging technologies such as generative AI.

This year's findings confirm that young people are not disengaged from news; rather, they are gravitating toward formats and voices they perceive as more entertaining, relatable, authentic, and easier to understand than traditional news brands.

The challenge for news organisations is to be able to appeal to new audiences through different, entertaining and engaging storytelling without compromising on the quality and credibility of their content.

Quality journalism underpins trust, and trust is the foundation of audience engagement, confirming the importance of high-quality journalism to our civic infrastructure and democracy.

KEY FINDINGS

Chapter 1: Value of journalism to audiences

- More than one-third (36%) of news consumers think the news media are doing a good job covering inflation and the cost of living.
- Three-quarters (77%) believe media owners influence news coverage.
- Almost one-third (30%) of 25–34-year-olds prefer news that shares their point of view compared to only 12% of 55–64s.
- Half (49%) of news consumers say public service media play a positive role in Australian life.
- Thirty-nine percent of right-wing consumers say that public service media have a negative effect on society.

Chapter 2: Changing news habits

- 60% of 18–24-year-olds have never read a printed newspaper.
- 18–24-year-olds' interest in news has risen sharply since 2024 (47%, +12).
- U35s are more interested in politics than those aged 35+.
- Younger people's news habits are fluid in relation to when, where, why, what and how they consume it.
- News avoidance remains high among Australians (68%).

Chapter 3: Generative AI, digital platforms & news

- Nearly one in ten Australians now use generative AI chatbots for news (9%, +3).
- Half (49%) of AI chatbot news consumers turn to them to follow up on news stories.
- AI news users value the chatbots' ability to aggregate, explain, and simplify news.
- Social media (37%) and AI chatbots (38%) have lower rates of click-through to news sources compared to search engines (45%).
- Users tend to click through search engines, social media and AI chatbots to get more details, but also click through AI chatbots to verify the news.

Chapter 4: News creators and influencers

- Forty-three percent of Australian news consumers get news from creators and influencers.
- News creators and influencers meet the needs of right-wing consumers (52%) more than left-wing (37%).
- News from creators and influencers is seen as more entertaining (59%), relatable (55%) and easier to understand (56%) than traditional news media.
- People who distrust mainstream news tend to view influencers as more trustworthy and authentic than traditional media.
- Right-wing news influencer users are more likely to see them as knowledgeable (54%) and trustworthy (47%) than left-wing (35%; 24%).

Chapter 5: News access

- Heavy news consumption has risen to 56% (+3), with strong growth among 18–24s (49%, +13 from 2023).
- Social media (56%, +9) is now the second most used general source of news, just behind TV (57%) and ahead of online news (52%, +5).
- Smart TV is used by more than half (52%) of Australian to access news.
- Social media (32%, +8) has overtaken direct access (31%, +1) as the main pathway to online news.
- More than one-third (35%, +6) of news consumers access seven or more news brands each week.

Chapter 6: Social media, news video & podcasting

- Almost half (48%, +12) of 18–24s use TikTok for news.
- Nearly three-quarters (73%, +6) watch news videos online each week.
- Podcast use is rising across the political spectrum, with increases among right-leaning (16%, +7) and left-leaning audiences (18%, +4).
- Interaction with news is growing with 40% talking about it with others and 39% reading comments on social media.
- Men and younger people are increasingly sharing news on social media.

Chapter 7: Trust and misinformation

- Trust in *my news* rose among under 35s (60%, +6), and traditional brands experienced a trust bump.
- Audiences trust *my news* (54%, +5) more than twice as much as news on social media (21%) or from AI chatbots (19%).
- High quality coverage of major issues is linked to higher trust in news.
- More than three quarters (77%, +3) are concerned about what is real or fake on the internet.
- Half of news consumers distrust news on social media (51%) and AI chatbots (49%).

Chapter 8: Paying for news

- Payment for online news has remained stable (23%, +1).
- Young people are increasingly paying for news (41% of 25–34, +7).
- Australia has the highest proportion of people paying for digital-only news brands (35%) globally.
- The top reasons for paying for news are to get exclusive content (46%) and an ad-free experience (39%).
- U35s (30%) are twice as likely than 35+ (15%) to pay for news to make sure news content is available free of charge to others.